

Make Your Own Theme

A theme changes how the game looks. It never changes how the game plays.

A theme is a folder of PNG images and one small text file, zipped up. You import it from **Options > Themes**, and it replaces the artwork on the board and the pieces.

The important thing to know before you start: **you almost certainly have to draw less than you think**. You do not draw a picture for every piece. You draw one blank for each piece *type*, and the game writes the designations on them. Anything you leave out falls back to the game's own artwork.



Four images and a text file. Every other piece, the captured tray, the board, and the Saboteur backs fall back to the game's own art.

What you can change

You can restyle	You cannot change
The six player colors	What any card does
Piece shapes, for every type	Menus, buttons, sounds
Captured-tray artwork	Any rule, anywhere
Saboteur backs	Piece numbering
Board halves	Board size or grid spacing
Card faces and backs	Card names or rules text
Menu and highlight colors	What a piece does

Start from the example, not from nothing

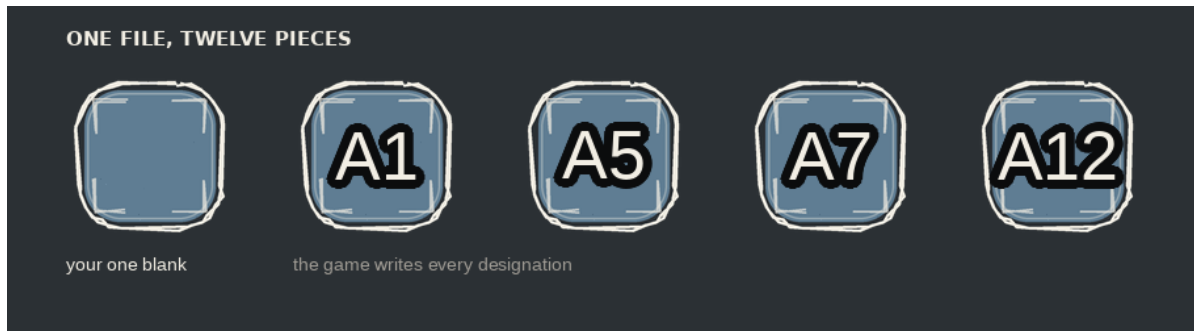
Save the **Theme Starter Pack** from the same screen where you found this guide. It is a complete working theme called Chalk & Slate. Unzip it, change two lines in `texture.json`, redraw whatever you like, zip it back up. Every filename is already correct and every image is already the right size.

THE IDEA

Blanks and designations

Each piece in Saboteur has a fixed designation - A1 through A12, B1 through B6, C1 through C3. Those never change, and they matter: A7 is A7 on the board, in the captured tray, and if it comes back into play later.

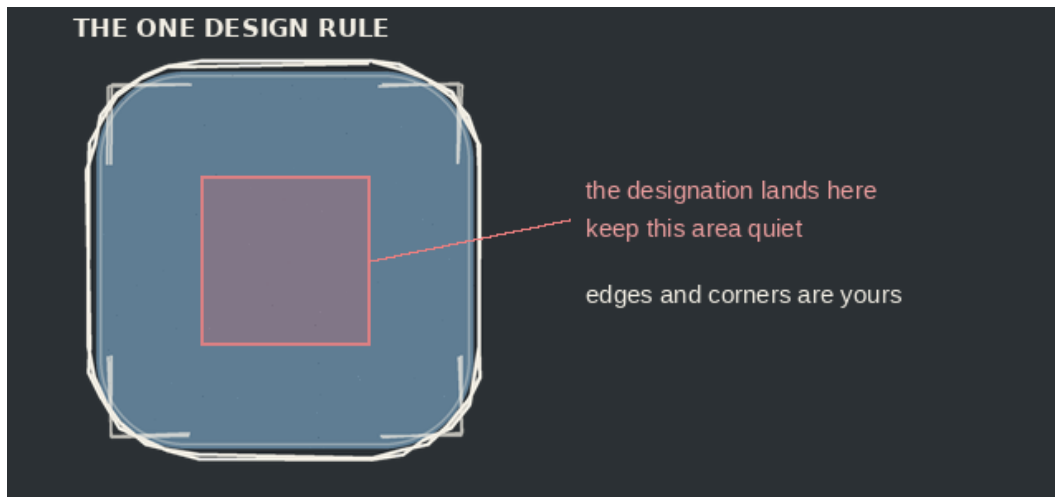
Drawing all of them by hand would mean 174 images per theme. So instead you draw a **blank** - the bare shape, with nothing written on it - and the game prints the designation over the middle.



One file covers all twelve A pieces. The same applies to B and C.

The one design rule

Because the designation is drawn in the center, **keep the center of your blanks fairly quiet**. Detail belongs at the edges and corners. This is the single mistake most likely to spoil a theme.



Roughly the middle 40 percent carries the text. Everything outside it is yours.

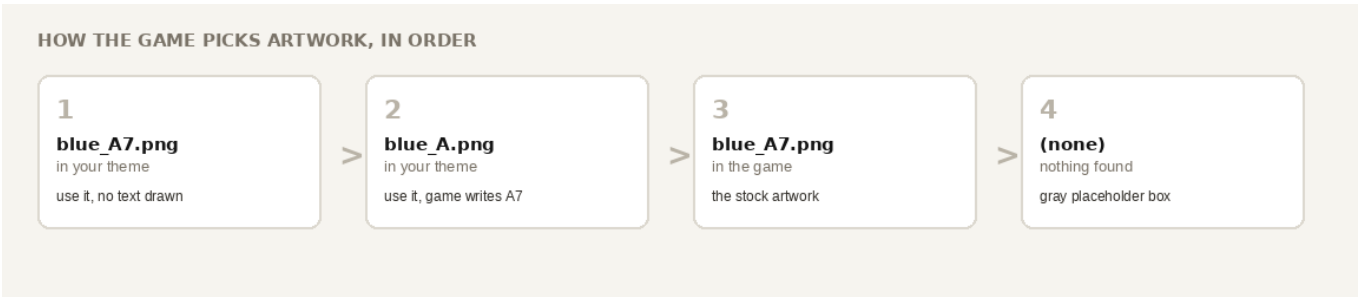
You can still draw the numbers yourself

If you want full control, supply the numbered file and it wins: `blue_A7.png` beats `blue_A.png`, and nothing is drawn over it. You can mix freely - blanks for most pieces, hand-drawn art for the few that matter to you. Setting `"labels": false` turns the feature off completely, and then all 174 are yours to make.

THE IDEA

How the game picks artwork

Every time the game needs a picture, it works down a list and stops at the first thing it finds. Understanding this list is what lets you make a small theme.



The order for a blue A7 piece. The same order applies to every image in the game.

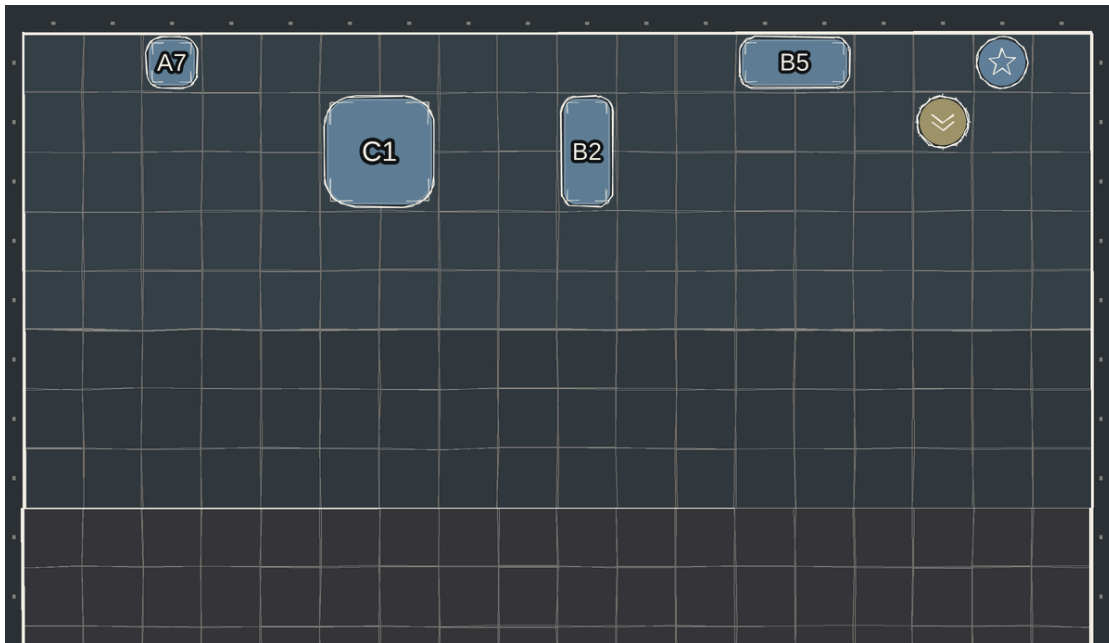
What this means in practice

If you...	Then...
Ship only four blanks in one color	That color is restyled. The other five use the game's art.
Ship blanks for all six colors	The whole board is yours. Tray, backs and board still fall back.
Skip the board folder entirely	The game's own board is used. This is fine and very common.
Skip the Saboteur backs	The game's backs are used. They will not match your style, but they work.
Misspell a filename	That one image falls through to the game's art. No error, just no change.
Ship a wrong-size image	It is used anyway, and looks stretched. The importer warns you.

Build it up in passes

Make four blanks in one color. Import it, start a game, look at it. Then do the other five colors. Then the tray. Then the backs. Then, if you still want to, the board. At no point is your theme broken or unusable - it just gets more complete.

Making a theme



Chalk & Slate, the example theme. Eighty-eight images; every designation drawn by the game.

1. Unzip the starter pack

You get a folder with `texture.json`, a `pieces` folder, and a `board` folder.

2. Rename it

Open `texture.json` in any text editor. Change `"id"` to something short and unique with no spaces - this becomes a folder name. Change `"name"` to whatever players should see. Put yourself in `"author"`.

3. Redraw what you want

Open any PNG and change it. Keep the filename and the pixel size exactly the same. Keep the middle of each blank quiet. Delete anything you do not want to include - it will fall back.

4. Set your colors

Edit the `palette` block so the menus and labels match your artwork. Check `pulse` and `ityd` too; see the color page.

5. Zip it

Zip the contents. `texture.json` must be inside - at the top level or one folder down, either works.

6. Import and look at it

Options > Themes > add a theme pack. If something is wrong the game tells you what. Then start a game and actually look.

The manifest

This is the whole of `texture.json`. It is the only file that is not optional.

```
{
  "id": "mytheme",
  "name": "My Theme",
  "author": "your name",
  "format": 1,

  "labels": true,
  "label_color": "#F2EEE4",
  "plate": false,

  "palette": {
    "blue": "#8FC2E8",
    "red": "#E88F93",
    "green": "#9ED69B",
    "yellow": "#EED98C",
    "magenta": "#E09FD4",
    "lavender": "#BBAEE8",
    "orange": "#EEA05A",
    "black": "#2B3034"
  },

  "pulse": "#8BE07A",
  "ityd": "#EED98C"
}
```

Key	Required	What it does
id	yes	Folder name. Unique, no spaces. Cannot be default or rosecourt.
name	yes	What players see in the Themes list.
author	no	Your name.
format	yes	Always 1 for now.
labels	no	true (the default) means you supply blanks and the game writes the designations.
label_color	no	Color of those designations. Must read against your blanks.
plate	no	Leave false. true adds a dark rectangle behind each piece, which only suits art that fills its whole square.
palette	no	The six player colors plus orange and black, used in menus and labels.
pulse	no	The glow on a revealed Saboteur.
ityd	no	The border marking captured pieces you can redeploy.

Colors are ordinary hex codes. A missing or misspelled one falls back to the game's value rather than breaking anything.

Pieces

Sizes

Every image must be exactly its listed size. The importer warns you if one is wrong.

Piece	Blank filename	Pixels	Cells
A	COLOR_A.png	128 x 128	1 x 1
B upright	COLOR_B_vertical.png	128 x 256	1 x 2
B on its side	COLOR_B_horizontal.png	256 x 128	2 x 1
C	COLOR_C.png	256 x 256	2 x 2
General	general_COLOR.png	128 x 128	1 x 1
Objective	objective_COLOR.png	128 x 128	1 x 1

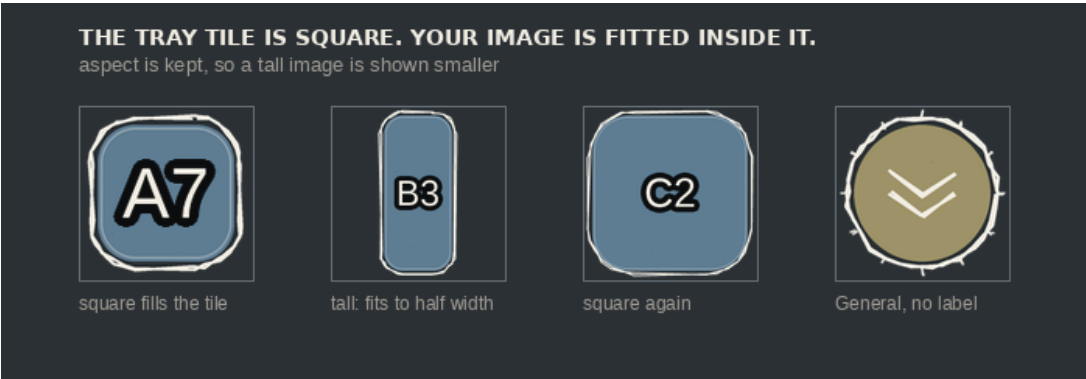
Replace **COLOR** with each of: blue red green yellow magenta lavender. B pieces rotate during play, so both orientations are separate images.

General and Objective never carry a designation, so nothing is drawn on them and their centers are free. Give them a distinct silhouette - players need to spot them instantly.

The captured tray

Captured pieces appear in a tray beside the board, one small icon per piece a player has lost.

The tile is square, and your image is fitted inside it. Aspect ratio is preserved, so a square image fills the tile and a taller one is centered and shown smaller. Any shape works; the shape you pick is a design decision, not a requirement.



The same tile, four different images.

Choosing a shape

Shape	Trade-off
Square (128 x 128)	Fills the tile. Largest, most readable designation. What the game's own art uses.
Tall (128 x 256)	Reads as a B at a glance, but shrinks to half width and the designation gets small.
Anything else	Works. Just check the designation is still readable once it is fitted.

Readability matters more here than anywhere else

Players read the tray when deciding which captured piece to bring back. If they cannot tell B3 from B5, your theme has taken away information they are entitled to. If you use a tall or narrow shape, capture a few pieces and check you can still read them without leaning in.

Filename	Covers
pieces/tray/tray_COLOR_A.png	All twelve A pieces
pieces/tray/tray_COLOR_B.png	All six B pieces, both orientations
pieces/tray/tray_COLOR_C.png	All three C pieces
pieces/tray/tray_COLOR_General.png	The General. No designation is drawn.

The tray B image has no `_vertical` or `_horizontal` - one image covers both. Objectives need no tray art; they never reach the tray.

Saboteur backs

When a piece is revealed as a Saboteur it flips to a back. These are the one set of images that are **not** per color - there are four, and the game chooses between them depending on who owns the piece and whether green is being played.



All four. The game never writes a designation on a back.

Filename stem	Used when
back_blackOnGreen	First player, green not in play
back_greenOnBlack	Second player, green not in play
back_blackOnOrange	First player, green in play
back_orangeOnBlack	Second player, green in play

Each stem needs four shapes, so sixteen files in total:

back_blackOnGreen_A.png	128 x 128
back_blackOnGreen_B_vertical.png	128 x 256
back_blackOnGreen_B_horizontal.png	256 x 128
back_blackOnGreen_C.png	256 x 256

Keep the S readable

A Saboteur back tells both players something they are entitled to see. A back that hides or obscures its S changes what people can read at the table, which is a rules change wearing a costume. Style it however you like, but keep it the first thing anyone notices.

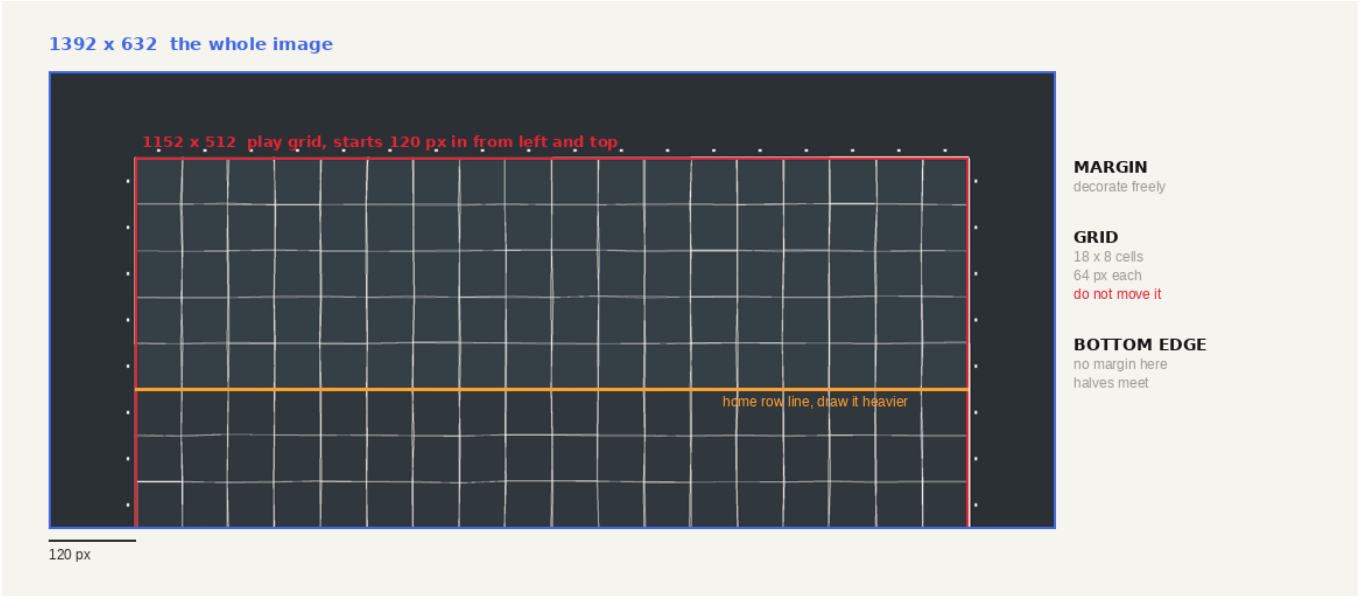
REFERENCE

Board art

Entirely optional. Change only the files you wish to.

If your theme has no board folder, the game uses its own board and everything still works.

The board is two images: a top half and a bottom half. The bottom is the same image flipped over, so **you only draw one per color** and the game handles the rest.



One half. The margin is yours to decorate. The grid inside it cannot move.

Measurement	Value
Whole image	1392 x 632 pixels, PNG
Play grid	1152 x 512, starting 120 px from the left and top
Cells	18 across, 8 down, 64 x 64 each
Bottom edge	No margin - this is where the two halves meet
Home row line	Between rows 5 and 6, at y = 440. Draw it heavier.
Filename	board/board_half_COLOR.png

Things worth knowing

The margin is free. Frames, texture, corner marks, a title - anything, as long as the grid stays where it is.

Keep cells legible. Pieces sit on top of the board. If the board is as busy or as bright as your pieces, nothing reads. The game's own board is deliberately pale for this reason.

PNG only, and no transparency needed. The board is the bottom layer, so give it a solid background.

Cards

Also entirely optional, and the biggest job in a theme.

A theme can replace the card faces. There are thirty-seven of them at 850 x 1190 pixels, and unlike the pieces there are no blanks - each card is its own illustration. Skip this page unless you want to take that on.

As everywhere else, any card you do not supply falls back to the game's own art. Supplying five cards is allowed; you will simply have a mixed deck.



From the Rose Court theme. Cards go in a cards/ folder.

Card backs

Ship card_back.png for a single back, or card_back_1.png and card_back_2.png to give each player their own. The numbered pair is tried first and falls back to the single file.

Card backs are mostly seen in online play, where you watch an opponent hold cards you cannot read. In local play on one screen there is little occasion to show one.

Charts and types

Filenames are fixed and derive from the game's mechanics, not from what the card is called. The effect is given so you know what you are illustrating.

Note the capital A in `major_onemanArmy.png` on the next page. Filenames are case-sensitive; that one is easy to get wrong.

CHARTS - twelve

`cards/chart_01.png` through `cards/chart_12.png`. Each shows a movement value for A, B and C. Combined with a Type card to declare a possible Saboteur.

TYPES - seven

Filename	Names
<code>cards/type_A.png</code>	A
<code>cards/type_B.png</code>	B
<code>cards/type_C.png</code>	C
<code>cards/type_AB.png</code>	A and B
<code>cards/type_AC.png</code>	A and C
<code>cards/type_BC.png</code>	B and C
<code>cards/type_ABC.png</code>	A, B and C

The power cards

Seventeen cards with one-off effects. The name in the filename is the game's internal shorthand, not necessarily what the card is called on its face.

MINOR POWERS - ten

Filename	Effect
cards/minor_justincase.png	After your next capture, draw two cards
cards/minor_getmoveon_A.png	Move one A piece two spaces
cards/minor_getmoveon_B.png	Move one B piece two spaces
cards/minor_getmoveon_C.png	Move one C piece two spaces
cards/minor_closecall_A.png	An A may capture a like piece instead of trading
cards/minor_closecall_B.png	As above, for B
cards/minor_closecall_C.png	As above, for C
cards/minor_ityd_A.png	Return one captured A piece to the board
cards/minor_ityd_B.png	As above, for B
cards/minor_ityd_C.png	As above, for C

MAJOR POWERS - seven

Filename	Effect
cards/major_blitzkrieg.png	Move two different pieces this turn
cards/major_doubleagent.png	Restore one declared Saboteur as your own piece
cards/major_heseemedusp.png	Capture one of your own pieces
cards/major_imontoyou.png	This turn, your General may capture a Saboteur
cards/major_ineffective.png	Your opponent cannot move their General for three turns
cards/major_justthisonce.png	Move your Objective up to three spaces
cards/major_onemanArmy.png	Play with a Type card; that type may capture a General

Colors

The palette

Six player colors. A game uses two of them at a time, chosen by the players, so **all six should be clearly distinguishable from each other** - any pair might end up facing each other.

These values are used for menu text, side labels, rule lines and highlights. They should roughly match your artwork, or the interface will disagree with the board.

Two more colors

pulse and ityd are used by the game to highlight things during play, not to identify a player.

If any of your piece colors are close to these, it could affect visibility. Pick something that stands apart from your six.

Testing your colors

Do this	Look for
Put all six swatches side by side	Any two that could be confused at a glance
Put pulse and ityd next to your six	They should not be mistaken for a player color
Set label_color against every blank	The designation should be readable on all six
Squint at the board with pieces on it	Pieces should stand out from the board

Complete file list

Everything a theme can contain. **Only** texture.json is required. Replace COLOR with each of blue, red, green, yellow, magenta, lavender.

texture.json	required
pieces/COLOR_A.png	128 x 128
pieces/COLOR_B_vertical.png	128 x 256
pieces/COLOR_B_horizontal.png	256 x 128
pieces/COLOR_C.png	256 x 256
pieces/general_COLOR.png	128 x 128
pieces/objective_COLOR.png	128 x 128
pieces/tray/tray_COLOR_A.png	square suits it best any aspect; fitted to a square tile
pieces/tray/tray_COLOR_B.png	
pieces/tray/tray_COLOR_C.png	
pieces/tray/tray_COLOR_General.png	
pieces/back_STEM_A.png	128 x 128
pieces/back_STEM_B_vertical.png	128 x 256
pieces/back_STEM_B_horizontal.png	256 x 128
pieces/back_STEM_C.png	256 x 256
board/board_half_COLOR.png	1392 x 632
cards/chart_01.png ... chart_12.png	850 x 1190
cards/type_A.png ... type_ABC.png	850 x 1190
cards/minor_*.png (10 cards)	850 x 1190
cards/major_*.png (7 cards)	850 x 1190
cards/card_back.png	850 x 1190
cards/card_back_1.png, card_back_2.png	optional pair

Group	Files	Skip it and...
Piece blanks, one color	4	that color uses the game's art
Piece blanks, all six colors	24	as above
General and Objective	12	the game's are used
Captured tray	24	the game's tray art is used
Saboteur backs	16	the game's backs are used
Board halves	6	the game's board is used
Card faces	37	the game's cards are used
Card backs	1 or 2	the game's back is used
Everything	120	

general_ and objective_ put the color *last*; A, B and C put it *first*. Filenames are case-sensitive.

Rules, testing and troubleshooting

Rules that are not negotiable

PNG only. SVG files are skipped with a warning - the game cannot read them while it is running. If you draw in vectors, export to PNG at the exact size.

Designations are fixed. A7 is A7 everywhere and forever. Never renumber a piece, never reuse a number, never make two pieces look alike.

Keep the S readable on Saboteur backs. See the backs page. This one is about fairness, not looks.

Keep the center of blanks quiet. The designation is drawn there.

Do not move the board grid. 1152 x 512 starting at 120,120. Decorate the margin instead.

Before you share it

Test	What you are checking
Play a full game with it	Nothing looks broken once pieces are captured or revealed
Capture one of every type	Tray art works and designations are readable
Reveal a Saboteur A, B and C	All the backs exist and read clearly
Play a game with green as a side	The orange Saboteur backs appear correctly
Look at the captured tray at arm's length	Designations still legible when small
Switch back to Default	Your theme uninstalls cleanly and nothing lingers

If something goes wrong

Nothing here is fatal. A theme with a problem still runs; the affected images just fall back to the game's own art.

What you see	What it means
Gray boxes instead of pieces	A filename is wrong. Check spelling, capitals, <code>_vertical</code> / <code>_horizontal</code> .
Some pieces yours, some not	That is the fallback working. The others are missing or misnamed.
Pieces stretched or wrong size	Wrong pixel dimensions. Check the file list.
No designations drawn	Set "labels" to true, or supply numbered files.
Designations drawn twice	You supplied a numbered file and set labels on. Remove one.
Designations hard to read	Change <code>label_color</code> , or quiet the center of the blank.
A dark square behind round pieces	Set "plate" to false.
Board unchanged	Board halves must be PNG, and named <code>board_half_COLOR.png</code> .
The zip will not import	<code>texture.json</code> is missing, or the id is taken.

Sharing

A theme is just a zip file. Send it to anyone and they import it the way you did. Themes are local - in an online game your opponent sees whichever theme they chose, so you never need to agree on one.

Wireframe Saboteur is a digital adaptation of The Saboteurs by Noah Matuszewski.